

# “This is not a self-help book.”

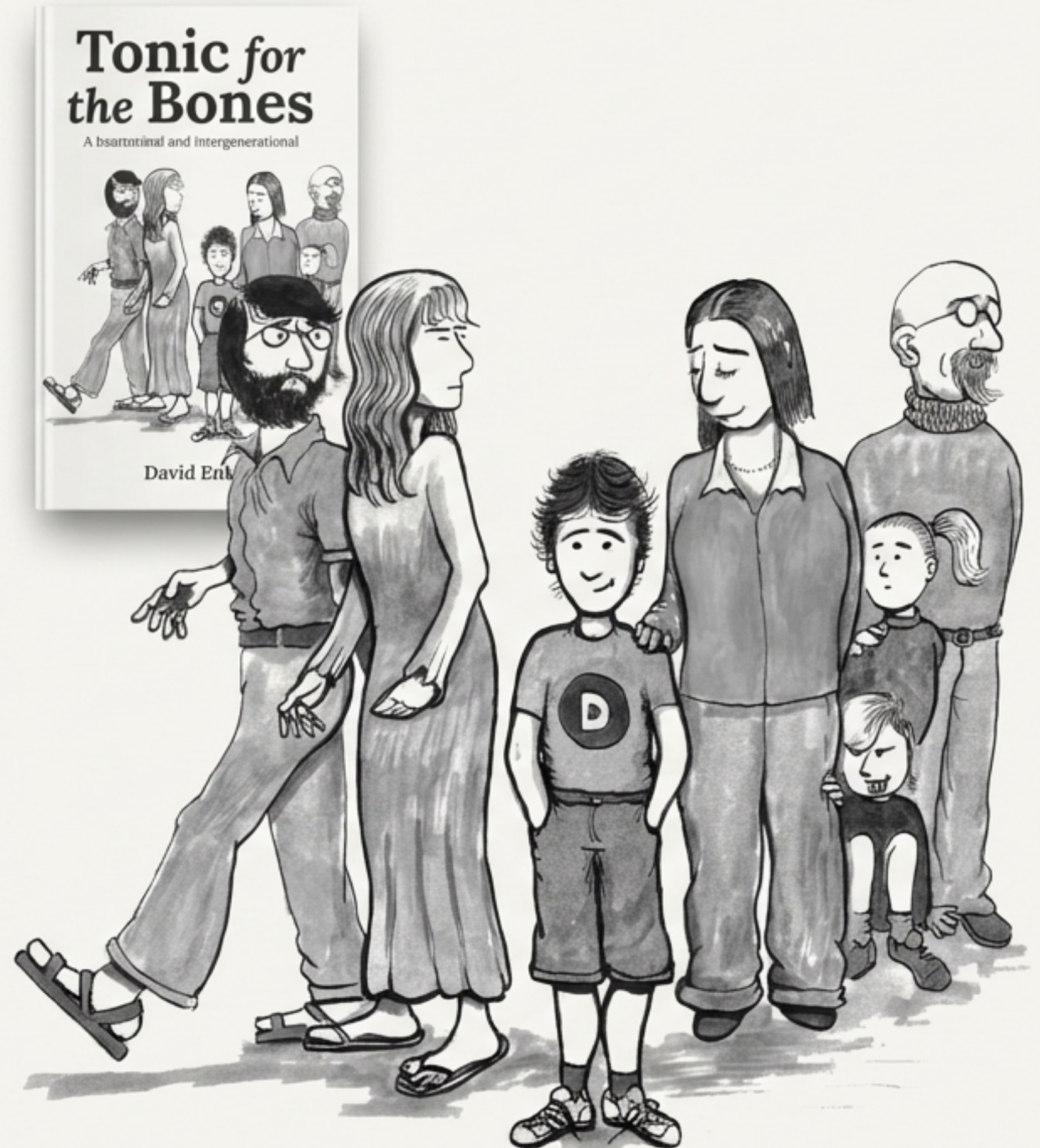
But it might help. *Just not in the way you expect.*

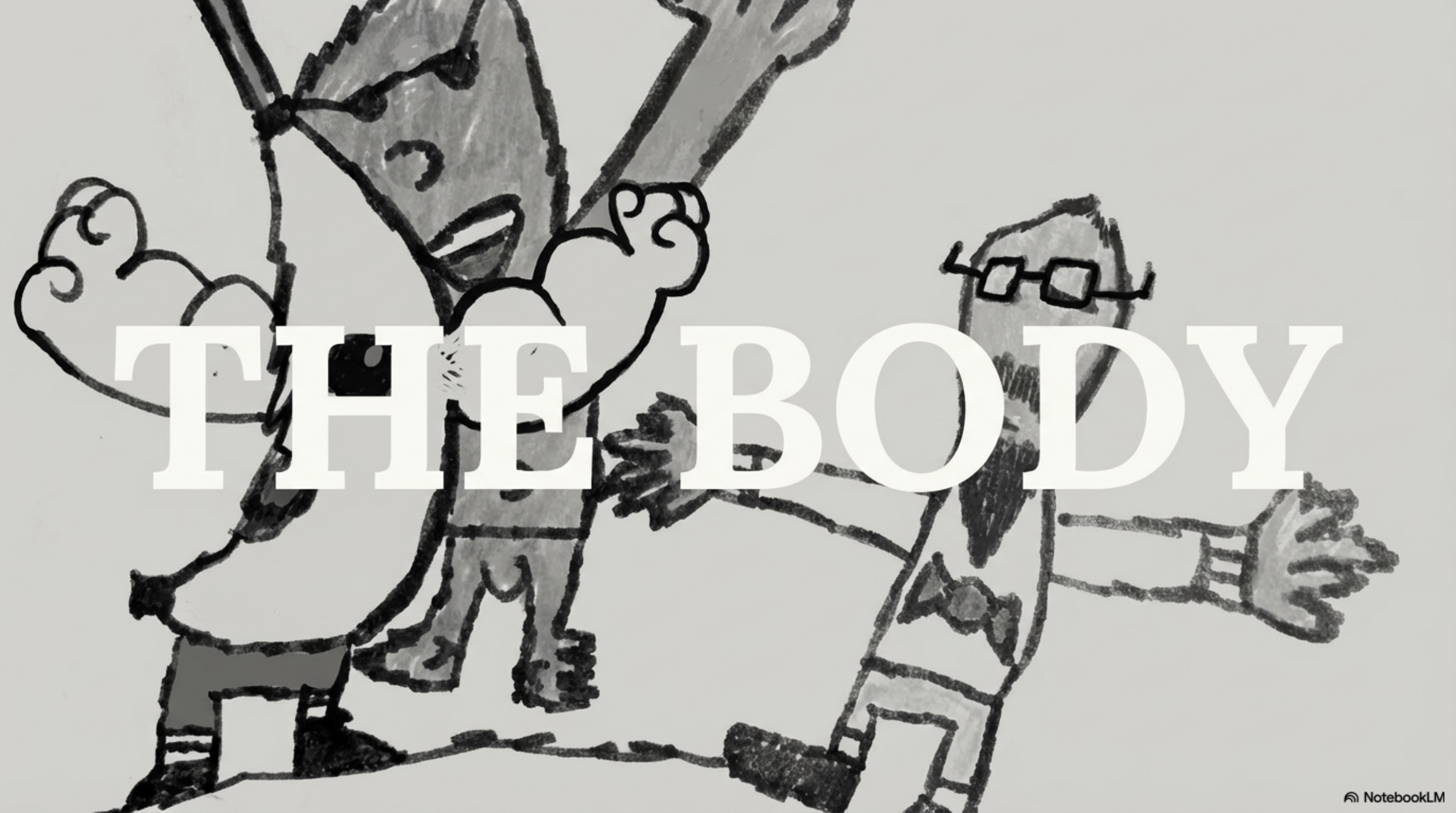


# A Writer's Journey Through Fracture.

David Enker is a writer and designer based in the Netherlands. His first book, *Phantom Parents*, explored adoption and intergenerational trauma through a patchwork memoir of stories and illustrations. *Tonic for the Bones* continues this journey, broadening the scope to include illness, fatherhood, and resilience.

**“This book looks not only at adoption and family legacy, adoption and family legacy, but also at illness, fatherhood, resilience, and the ways art and imagination can carry us through fracture.”**





# THE BODY

# “Just Parkinson’s.”

It started with dismissed symptoms—loss of smell, an arm that no longer swings—and a Dr. Google search. The DAT scan results came with a technician’s terrifying, mistaken report: a life expectancy of only a few years. The weekend was lived under a death sentence. Then came the neurologist’s correction: “You most likely just have Parkinson’s. You won’t die from Parkinson’s—just with it.” Relief. Weeks later, the L-Dopa kicks in, making him feel like a new man. With Parkinson’s.

*“I let out a neurotic laugh, making some ridiculous joke about Awakenings—Robin Williams as Oliver Sacks, bringing patients to life.”*

# Is there a link between trauma and Parkinson's?

The story of Oma T, a woman from David's childhood who shook constantly. A survivor of the Japanese camps in Indonesia, she never spoke of the war.

After his own diagnosis, David learned her tremor was never diagnosed as Parkinson's. Her daughter's explanation: 'She was just traumatized.'

This anecdote opens a broader inquiry into inherited trauma—from Jewish great-grandparents murdered in Auschwitz to the preverbal scars of adoption—and how it might express itself differently in each body.

*I'm beginning to think that trauma—whether physical or emotional—expresses itself differently in each body. Some people develop cancer, others Alzheimer's, and still others, Parkinson's.*



# THE MIND



*“The world is an infinitely dark and evil place, but you, my son... you are a bright light.”*

The slide recounts David's final visit with his biological father, Rogier, a melancholic man eaten by cancer. In a messy apartment filled with books on 'negative interests' and literary treasures, they connect through the music of Skip James. The visit culminates father's final words, calling David 'my son' for the first time.

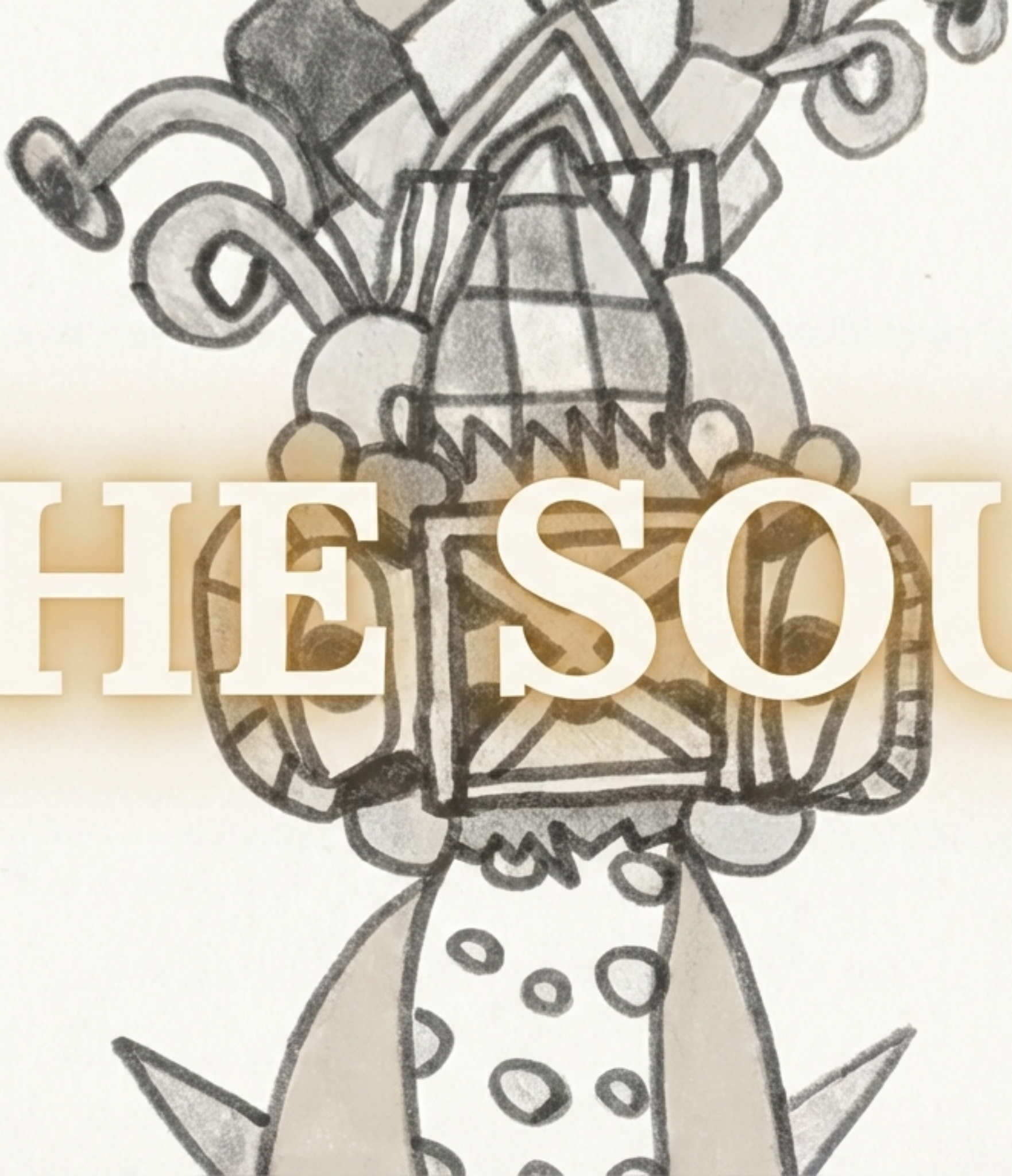
He looks me in the eyes and says, 'The world is an infinitely dark and evil place, but you, my son... you are a bright light, the best thing that ever happened to me.'”

# The Broken Circle

Days after his son Yaron was born, David's birth mother, Esther, visits during a heatwave. Amidst the exhaustion of new parenthood, her first question is, "Are you having him circumcised?" She ignores the new parents, dumps a bag of second-hand teddy bears, and launches into a verbal avalanche about "my father," "Holocaust," and "Israel," capturing the profound sense of alienation David feels.

***"Sweat runs down my back, cold and clammy against the heat of the room. Looking at her, a chill crawls up my spine. She sits only six feet away, on our couch, but the distance between us is unbridgeable. She is an unknown entity. A stranger with my face."***

It was the last time we spoke.



# THE SOUL

# An Invitation to the Deep.

*“You think I arrived late. / But I was in the  
dark matter / But I was in the dark matter /  
between your neurons, /  
long before words.*

*You call me affliction. / A curse. / Bad luck. /  
I call myself / a witness. / A mirror. /  
An invitation to the deep.*

*I’ll take things from you. / The swing of your  
arm, / the ease of sleep, / your speed. / But if  
you stay / I’ll give you / clarity, / honesty, /  
a sliver of gold / beneath the rubble.”*



# “I love you daddy.”



## Shaken, Not Heard

After David falls at the football pitch, his son Yaron sits next to him and puts his arm around him, ‘like the father I never had.’



## He Said It First

After his bedtime routine, Yaron says ‘I love you daddy’ for the first time.

David reflects: ‘Nailed to ground, melting through the floor, I realise I never said that to him, and he never to me. Sometimes words don’t need to be spoken, sometimes they do.’

# The Art & Soul of Adversity.

The book is filled with illustrations by David's son, Yaron. His creative output—comics about 'The Battle,' family trees, inventions like 'Jimmy' behind the wall of the universe—reflects and processes their shared reality. This creative partnership is a primary source of resilience and wonder.

*From the story 'Jimmy': 'He drew another lemniscate next to the previous one, and connected the two "flat eights" with 3 lines... he said, this is Jimmy.'*

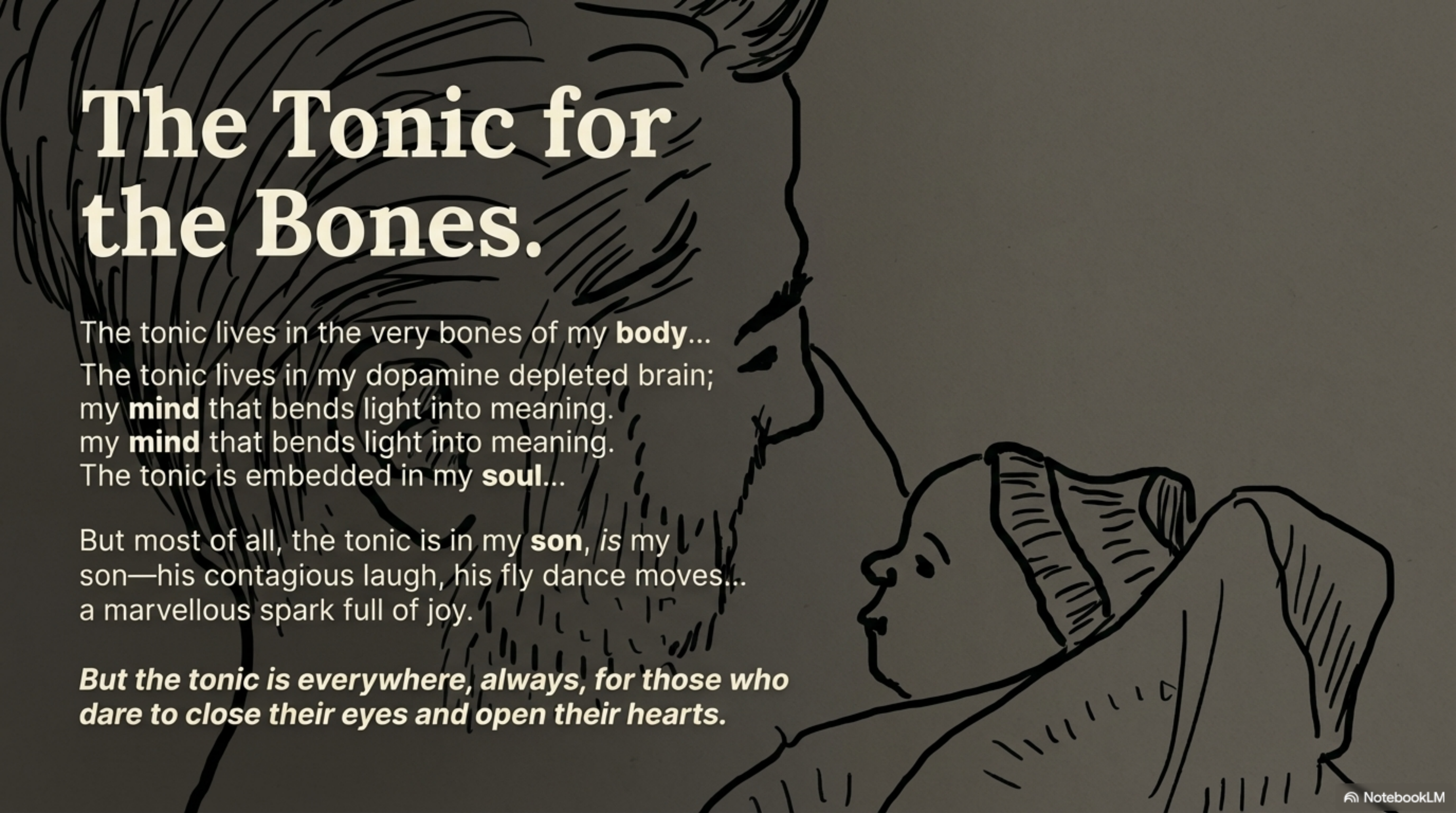


# Healing isn't looking back. It's a reroute.

The story 'Healing: Heart Wide Open' recounts David's experiment with the 'Beech Band,' a device meant to replicate a mother's heartbeat. While the womb is no sanctuary for him, the device's rhythm connects him to his son's pencil tapping as he draws. This leads to a moment of 'ghost of normality' where his arm swings freely, offering a profound insight rather than a cure.



***“Not a cure. A sidepath sort of healing: the ability to live with both wound and wonder... If Parkinson's is a sneaky ghost, then healing might be its mischievous twin — brass but invisible, fleeting, knocking on the bones just to say: you're still here.”***



# The Tonic for the Bones.

The tonic lives in the very bones of my **body**...

The tonic lives in my dopamine depleted brain;  
my **mind** that bends light into meaning.

my **mind** that bends light into meaning.

The tonic is embedded in my **soul**...

But most of all, the tonic is in my **son**, is my  
son—his contagious laugh, his fly dance moves...  
a marvellous spark full of joy.

*But the tonic is everywhere, always, for those who  
dare to close their eyes and open their hearts.*

# David Enker

Writer // Designer // The Stand-up Parkinsonian

Exploring the future of interfaces, AI, and VR as ways to navigate limitations.  
Connecting with fellow builders, dreamers, and question-askers.

**Book:** *Tonic for the Bones* (Coming 2026)

**Website & Projects:** [davidenker.com](http://davidenker.com)

